



The real story of Columbus

Columbus was an evil hack who never set foot in America and thought the Earth was pear-shaped. <https://digit.in/jul20-65>



How Kon Tiki misled the world

All the misconceptions about navigating in the Pacific that came about after the Kon-Tiki voyage. <https://digit.in/jul20-66>



The Kon-Tiki Raft

Credit: Denis Kudlay / Shutterstock.com

CROSSING THE PACIFIC

Who made it first to the new world?

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Ihe simple truth is that Columbus did not discover America. Yes, sure there were people already there, but that is not what this article is about. Nor is it about the voyages by John Cabot or Amerigo Vespucci. Even in historic times, there have been instances where people have reached America, and this has happened multiple times. The problem is that there are many theories and studies that showed that the Austronesians, Polynesians, Eskimos, Siberians and Vikings made the journey across either the Pacific or Atlantic oceans. However,

many of these studies are considered controversial, and in fact, some of them are delegated to the category of pseudoscience. In the northern regions, the cold temperatures mean that the soft organic materials used by men such as animal hides and bones are well preserved. In the tropics though, this is not the case, and we have to go by more roundabout pieces of evidence, such as common words used in two regions, or the existence of certain plants that could not possibly have crossed the oceans themselves, or similarities in the genetics of populations on either side of the ocean. Before looking at the contact that might have happened, let us look at the crossings that we have evidence of.

VINLAND

Norse sagas made mention of a land west of the Atlantic, with a camp being described in The Saga of Erik the Red.

The remains of this camp was discovered in 1960 in New Foundland, the only Norse site outside of Greenland. Leif Erikson made the voyage across the Atlantic some time around 1000 CE. Vinland is the name given to the place by the Norse. The Scandinavians explored the oceans using their boats, and were responsible for colonising Greenland. It was one of these exploratory expeditions that reached the eastern coast of America. While the Norse did not colonise this new land that they found, they did establish a semi permanent camp, and made multiple voyages over the course of a century.

Contact across the ocean happened on the other side of the continent as well, across the Bering Strait between Siberia and Alaska. While entire bands of people crossed over to the Americas through the Bering Strait. More about these crossings can be read in this month's dmystify. There